Kō

The year, in seventy-two

FOOD-INCLUSIVE TWO-PAGE SEASON PILOT

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牡丹華

Peonies bloom

Botan hana saku

Peonies open their heavy, fragrant blooms as late spring reaches its most opulent moment before giving way to summer.

NATURE / Peonies heavy with dew bow toward the earth each morning, their blooms so full they barely hold their form.

Seasonal food

FRUIT	VEGETABLES	FISH & SEAFOOD
Loquat	Bamboo shoots	Horse mackerel
Late strawberries	Fava beans	Bonito
Green ume plums	New ginger	Flounder
Early cherries	Mitsuba	

AT THE TABLE / Takenoko gohan; Katsuo no tataki

CULTURE / The peony, known as the 'king of flowers,' has long symbolized nobility, prosperity, and feminine beauty in Japanese art.

牡丹散りて打ちかさなりぬ二三片

Peony petals fall — / two, three, overlapping / on the garden stone



蓮始開

Lotus blossoms open

Hasu hajimete hiraku

Lotus flowers unfurl their pale pink petals at dawn, perfuming temple ponds with their sweet, otherworldly fragrance.

NATURE / Dragonflies patrol the lotus ponds in territorial circuits, their wings catching the morning light like flecks of mica.

Seasonal food

FRUIT	VEGETABLES	FISH & SEAFOOD
watermelon	lotus root	conger eel
white peach	shiso leaves	sweetfish
muscat grapes	bitter melon	horse mackerel
akebi melon	tōgan (winter melon)	

AT THE TABLE / hasu no kinpira; gōya champurū; tōgan no soboroni; shirauo no kakiage

CULTURE / At Shinobazu Pond in Ueno and lotus-viewing sites across Japan, early risers gather for kanren — lotus appreciation.

蓮開く音なき音に目覚めけり

lotus opening — / I wake to the soundless sound / of its unfolding



鴻雁来

Wild geese arrive from the north

Kōgan kitaru

The first skeins of wild geese cross autumn skies, their calls announcing the deepening of the season as cold dew settles on morning fields.

NATURE / Wild geese from Siberia begin their annual arrival at Japan's lakes and coastal marshlands, their calls echoing across water surfaces pearled with morning dew.

Seasonal food

FRUIT

Kaki (persimmon)

Karin (Chinese quince)

Mukago (mountain yam bulbils)

Yamabudo (wild mountain grape)

VEGETABLES

Ginnan (ginkgo nut)

Satoimo (taro root)

Shimeji (beech mushroom)

Shungiku (garland chrysanthemum)

FISH & SEAFOOD

Sawara (Spanish mackerel)

Hatatehagi (filefish)

Hirame (flounder)

AT THE TABLE / Kamo-nanban soba; Hirame no kobujime; Mukago gohan; Kaki no namerō

CULTURE / The arrival of the wild geese has been watched for centuries as confirmation that autumn has truly settled in.

雁の声遠き湖面に波紋かな

wild goose calls — / across the distant lake / ripples spread



芹乃栄

Water parsley flourishes

Seri sunawachi sakau

EDITORIAL COPY PENDING

Fruit, vegetables, fish, dishes, nature, culture, and haiku remain unfilled until this season's source letter is available and reviewed.

FRUIT

VEGETABLES

FISH & SEAFOOD